

Youngee Son

Updated: August 2026

Department of Economics
Michigan State University
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Fields

Health Economics, Labor Economics

Education

2022 – 2027 (Expected)	Ph.D., Economics, Michigan State University <i>Committee:</i> Todd Elder (Chair), Stacy Dickert-Conlin, Hanzhe Zhang
2022 – 2024	M.A., Economics, Michigan State University
2010 – 2016	B.A., Economics, Korea University

Job Market Paper

“Organ Availability and Transplant Candidate Behavior”

Liver transplant candidates decline more than half of the organs offered to them, even though no alternative treatment exists. Each year, roughly one in eight dies or becomes too sick for transplant while waiting. This paper studies how candidates make these decisions. The 2020 Acuity Circles reform changed how candidates are prioritized, redrawing both the geographic boundaries and redefining the medical urgency groups. Using offer-level data from the Scientific Registry of Transplant Recipients, I show that candidates who gained access became more selective: a one-standard-deviation increase in expected offer arrival rates lowers the probability of accepting an offer by 4.7 percentage points, a 12.6 percent decline. To interpret this behavior, I estimate a dynamic discrete choice model of the accept-or-wait decision. Candidates weigh the offer at hand against the chance of a better offer later, knowing they may die or become too sick while waiting. The estimated model implies that the reform raised average welfare at listing by an amount equivalent to roughly doubling donor supply, with only 1.6 percent of candidates made worse off. I then evaluate several counterfactual policy changes, including a widely debated one which would replace the remaining boundaries with a continuous score that incorporates both medical urgency and proximity. I find that prioritizing the sickest candidates raises average welfare but at the cost of wasted organs.

Research and Professional Experience

2024 – Present	Research Assistant to Professor Todd Elder, Michigan State University
2016 – 2022	Junior Economist, Bank of Korea

Presentations

2026	Missouri Valley Economic Association Annual Meeting (scheduled); MSU Grand River Conference; MSU Applied Microeconomics Seminar; MSU Economics Graduate Student Seminar
2025	Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting; MSU Red Cedar Conference; MSU Economics Graduate Student Seminar

Fellowships, Awards, and Honors

- 2026 | Summer Research Fellowship, Department of Economics, Michigan State University
- 2025 | Red Cedar Award (best third-year paper), Department of Economics, Michigan State University
- 2023 | Peter Schmidt Award, Honorable Mention (best first-year Ph.D. student), Department of Economics, Michigan State University

Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant, Michigan State University

- Fall 2026 | Advanced Econometrics I (Graduate); Analysis of Labor Markets
- Spring 2026 | Advanced Data Analysis in Economics
- Fall 2025 | Econometrics IA (Graduate)
- Fall 2024 | Analysis of Labor Markets
- Spring 2024 | Microeconomics II (Graduate)
- Fall 2023 | Introduction to Econometric Methods
- Spring 2023 | Macroeconomics and Public Policy
- Fall 2022 | Introduction to Macroeconomics

Service

- 2024 – 2025 | Board Member, Economics Graduate Student Organization, Michigan State University

Skills

Programming & Software: Stata, R, Python, MATLAB,
Methods: Causal inference, Structural modeling, Supervised/unsupervised machine learning, NLP
Data: Exploratory Data Analysis and Visualization
Languages: Korean (native), English (fluent)

References

Todd Elder (Chair) Professor of Economics Michigan State University telder@msu.edu	Stacy Dickert-Conlin Professor of Economics Michigan State University dickertc@msu.edu	Hanzhe Zhang Professor of Economics Michigan State University hanzhe@msu.edu
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